

Educating the Commonwealth

A working book brief

September 2026

I am writing Educating the Commonwealth because I believe education has become too narrow at precisely the moment when young people need a larger understanding of the world.

The idea for the book

Students are prepared to enter an economy, but they are rarely taught how that economy works. They learn how to complete assignments, earn credentials, and compete for opportunities, but they are not consistently given the language to understand who owns the resources around them, who makes decisions, who benefits from investment, why some neighborhoods accumulate assets while others lose them, or how communities might build something different together.

Every student already lives inside a political economy. Housing, food, transportation, healthcare, technology, work, land, public finance, and access to education shape daily life long before a student is old enough to name them. These systems affect where families live, what they can afford, whether they feel safe, what opportunities they can imagine, and whether they believe institutions are working for them.

Yet schools often present the economy as something external and inevitable. Students may learn about supply and demand without studying the stores, landlords, employers, agencies, and public decisions that shape their neighborhoods. They may learn civics without examining who controls the land, capital, infrastructure, and institutions that make civic participation possible. They may learn the big names and broad arcs of national history without understanding the lived, local history of how previous generations built schools, libraries, unions, cooperatives, hospitals, parks, churches, neighborhood associations, and mutual-aid societies.

Educating the Commonwealth is an attempt to bring those questions into the classroom. The book is a practical and historical guide for educators who want students to understand and participate in the systems that shape their lives. It is not a textbook about economics detached from experience. It is not a conventional civics book that treats democracy as a set of governmental procedures. It is not a manifesto asking teachers to impose a political worldview on students. It is a guide to helping students investigate the world they already inhabit.

The central premise is that education should help people inherit, question, repair, and build the commonwealth.

By commonwealth, I mean the material, institutional, cultural, and relational inheritance that makes shared life possible. It includes schools and libraries, public hospitals and parks, transportation systems and neighborhood businesses, local knowledge and public trust, community organizations and democratic habits. Some parts of that inheritance are formal and visible. Others are informal, fragile, or nearly forgotten.

The commonwealth is not simply what government owns. It is the field of resources, relationships, institutions, and responsibilities that a society creates and passes between generations.

Economic democracy as a classroom practice

That inheritance is uneven. Some students grow up surrounded by stable institutions, accumulated assets, strong networks, and visible pathways into opportunity. Others inherit debt, displacement, underinvestment, environmental risk, institutional distrust, and the consequences of decisions made without their participation.

Education cannot solve all of those conditions. But education can help people see them. It can give students the tools to ask better questions, gather evidence, listen to people affected by a problem, identify competing interests, understand institutional constraints, imagine alternatives, and contribute something useful.

That is where economic democracy enters the book. I use economic democracy not as an abstract doctrine, but as a way of asking practical questions: Who owns the resources around us? Who makes decisions? Who benefits from public or private investment? Who bears the risk? What forms of shared ownership or stewardship are possible? How can communities build assets that last? What responsibilities do people have toward institutions they inherit?

These questions connect economic life to democratic judgment. They help students understand that the economy is not merely about money, jobs, or consumption. It is also about power, belonging, responsibility, and the capacity to act together.

Learning through real community problems

The book would organize this work around real community problems. Students might investigate food affordability, housing, transportation, public health, local history, climate, neighborhood business, workforce development, or the future of a public institution. They might create a map, conduct interviews, examine data, document a history, design a public resource, develop a proposal, or present recommendations to an agency or community organization.

The important point is that learning would not end with an answer on a test. A meaningful project would leave behind knowledge, relationships, and an asset that others could use.

A class might study why healthy food is difficult to access in one neighborhood. Students would not simply write an essay about food deserts. They might map stores and transportation routes, interview residents, examine pricing and land use, compare public and private responses, speak with local businesses, and design a community resource or recommendation.

Another class might investigate housing. Students could study ownership, rent, displacement, zoning, property taxes, community land trusts, and neighborhood history. They could learn that housing is simultaneously a home, an asset, a public concern, and a site of political decision-making.

Another class might examine the history of a school or public institution. Students could ask who created it, what needs it originally served, who has access to it now, and what it might become in the future.

The project is not simply to produce more informed students. It is to cultivate people who know how to observe, listen, research, deliberate, collaborate, and build.

The opportunity

The opportunity is to connect several conversations that are usually kept apart. Education reform often focuses on achievement, assessment, technology, college access, and workforce preparation. Civic education often focuses on government, elections, constitutional principles, and public participation. Economic-development work focuses on jobs, entrepreneurship, investment, business formation, and regional growth. Community development focuses on housing, health, land, public services, and neighborhood institutions.

All of those fields are related, but they rarely share a common language. *Educating the Commonwealth* could create that language.

The book could give teachers a way to connect the classroom to the economic and civic realities students already recognize. It could give community organizations a method for working with schools without reducing schools to pipelines for labor or recruitment. It could give public agencies a way to understand students as contributors to local knowledge rather than passive recipients of programs. It could give philanthropic and institutional leaders a framework for supporting education that produces durable public value.

There is also a cultural opportunity. Many people sense that something fundamental about the American economy is not working. They see rising housing costs, fragile employment, concentrated ownership, declining trust, social isolation, political polarization, and institutions that seem unable to respond to ordinary problems. But they lack a shared language for understanding how these conditions connect.

Young people often feel the consequences before they understand the structures. They experience the cost of education, housing, transportation, technology, and healthcare. They see the difference between neighborhoods. They encounter systems that ask them to be resilient without explaining why so many systems are becoming more difficult to navigate.

The book would offer a language that is neither fatalistic nor naive. It would not tell students that every problem can be solved by individual effort. It would also not tell them that they are powerless until a perfect political transformation arrives. It would help them see the space between individual action and large-scale structural change: the space of institutions, relationships, local decisions, shared assets, and organized work.

That space is where democratic life becomes tangible.

Schools as civic infrastructure

The opportunity is especially strong because schools remain among the few institutions that bring generations of people together. A school touches students, families, educators, public agencies, community organizations, employers, cultural institutions, and neighborhood networks. Schools are imperfect and often overburdened, but they remain places where society can practice how to live together.

The book would not ask schools to become everything. It would ask them to recover part of their civic purpose.

A school should prepare students not only to find a place in the economy, but to understand the economy as something human beings make and govern. It should prepare them not only for private advancement, but for shared responsibility. It should help them see that a neighborhood is not just a market, a public institution is not just a service provider, and a community is not just a collection of individuals.

The most important opportunity may be to redefine what counts as educational success. A student who can memorize information but cannot listen to another person, evaluate evidence, understand institutional power, work across disagreement, or contribute to a shared project is not fully prepared for democratic life.

A strong educational project should produce more than a grade. It should produce knowledge that matters, relationships that continue, and work that can be used. That is the standard I want the book to introduce.

Why me

I am uniquely positioned to write this book because I have spent my life moving between education, community development, entrepreneurship, institutions, and public purpose.

I did not come to this question from one discipline. I came to it through a series of experiences that gradually revealed the same underlying problem.

I have been shaped by education as a student, teacher, family inheritance, public institution, and field of work. I have seen schools as places where young people learn, but also as places where communities express their hopes, conflicts, memories, and ambitions.

My family history gives me a personal connection to the question of public education. My father's work, my family's movement through New York, the history of the Bronx, and the unfinished stories passed between generations have made education feel less like an abstract policy category and more like an inheritance.

I understand that schools carry more than curriculum. They carry memory. They carry opportunity. They carry the promise that a person's future should not be determined entirely by the circumstances into which they are born.

I have also spent years building entrepreneurial and economic-development ecosystems. That experience taught me that education cannot be separated from ownership, capital, institutions, and the conditions under which people work.

People are often told that education is the pathway to opportunity, but opportunity depends on more than individual preparation. It depends on whether communities have assets, whether institutions are trustworthy, whether people can access capital, whether businesses are rooted in place, whether public investment is accountable, and whether the benefits of growth are shared.

I have worked close enough to organizations, funders, entrepreneurs, boards, public agencies, and community initiatives to see both the promise and the limits of institutional solutions.

I have seen good ideas fail because they were disconnected from place. I have seen programs produce activity without building durable capacity. I have seen organizations speak about community benefit while retaining control over the resources that communities actually need.

Those experiences inform the book's emphasis on contribution, stewardship, and shared ownership.

I am also positioned to write this book because I have learned to translate between worlds: educators and investors; students and institutions; public agencies and community organizations; economic theory and lived experience; personal history and public purpose.

That translation is essential because the book's audience is not one profession. It includes teachers, school leaders, students, parents, community organizations, public officials, funders, and people trying to imagine institutions that work differently.

I am not writing from the position of someone who has solved these problems. I am writing from the position of someone who has spent decades learning how they connect.

My authority comes from participation, not distance. I have tried to build institutions. I have made mistakes. I have encountered governance problems, financial pressures, personal limits, and the gap between what an organization intends and what it can actually sustain. I have seen how hard it is to create shared purpose in a world organized around individual achievement and private control.

That experience keeps the book honest. I do not want to write a book that romanticizes communities or schools. I want to write a book that respects their complexity and gives people practical tools for working within it.

Why now

I am writing this book now because the old separation between education, democracy, and the economy is becoming impossible to maintain.

Students are entering a world in which institutions are changing faster than traditional curricula can explain. Technology is reshaping work and public life. Housing and healthcare are increasingly unstable. Communities are dealing with climate pressure, political distrust, social isolation, and declining confidence in public institutions.

At the same time, schools are being asked to carry more responsibility while receiving less clarity about their purpose. They are expected to prepare students for work, citizenship, technology, college, mental-health challenges, social conflict, and economic uncertainty. But these responsibilities are often treated as separate initiatives rather than parts of one larger question: What does it mean to educate people for shared life?

The answer cannot be a return to an imaginary past. Schools have never been perfect. Civic institutions have always been contested. The commonwealth has always been distributed unequally. But the current moment makes it urgent to recover the idea that education is a public practice.

We need an education that helps people understand the systems they inherit without convincing them that those systems are permanent. We need students who can examine evidence without losing their capacity for imagination. We need people who can disagree without abandoning one another. We need communities that can build assets instead of merely responding to crisis.

Economic democracy can sound abstract when it is discussed only through ownership models, policy language, or institutional theory. Education offers a way to make it concrete. Students can begin with the places they know. They can ask who owns the building, who controls the land, how the food arrived, where the money came from, who benefits from development, and what responsibilities institutions have to the people they serve.

These are not secondary questions. They are the substance of democratic life.

Many educators are already doing this work intuitively. Teachers are asking students to investigate local history, study environmental conditions, work with community organizations, document oral histories, and create public projects. But they often lack a framework that connects those practices to a larger theory of civic and economic life.

Educating the Commonwealth would name and organize what is already emerging. It would say that project-based learning is not simply a teaching technique. It can be a form of civic formation. Community engagement is not an extracurricular activity. It can be a way for students to understand responsibility and power. Economic literacy is not just personal finance. It includes ownership, governance, public investment, shared assets, and the ability to reason about collective choices.

What I really want to do

What I really want to do is make a different future imaginable and practical.

I want students to understand that they are not merely preparing to inherit a broken world. They are already participating in the making of the world around them.

I want educators to have a framework that respects their intelligence and gives them room to begin with real questions rather than predetermined answers.

I want communities to see schools not only as places that deliver education, but as places that can help people understand local conditions, preserve memory, build relationships, and create public assets.

I want economic democracy to become something people can teach, practice, and recognize.

The book should be useful enough to enter a classroom, serious enough to enter a university or policy conversation, and human enough to speak to families and communities. It should not end with a theory. It should invite a practice.

The practice is simple to state, even if it is difficult to sustain: Notice the place. Ask better questions. Listen to the people affected. Study the evidence. Understand the systems. Work across difference. Create something useful. Return value to the community.

That is the beginning of a civic education.

The opportunity before me is to turn the accumulated material of my life - education, family history, entrepreneurship, economic development, institutional work, public systems, and economic-democracy thinking - into a coherent public offering.

Never Build Alone tells the story of how I came to these questions. *Educating the Commonwealth* can show what I want to do with them. One book is the inward journey. The other is the public method.